# Analysis & Deconstruction

## TEAMFIGHT TACTICS

# Overview

**Release date:** June 26, 2019 (PC) / March 19, 2020 (iOS & Android)
**Genre:** Auto-chess / Strategy
**Platform:** Windows, macOS / iOS / Android
**Rating:** PEGI 12
**Players:** 8

## An auto-battler set in the world of Runeterra!

- Constant game renewal through **seasonal updates**
- Intuitive **gameplay**, while preserving the **competitive edge**
- Your LoL champions available to everyone!

Manage and pit your **favorite champions** from every corner of **Runeterra** against each other! Assemble your dream team, place them **wisely** on your **board**, and defeat your opponents by being the **last one standing**!

# 3C - Camera

**Main Camera:**

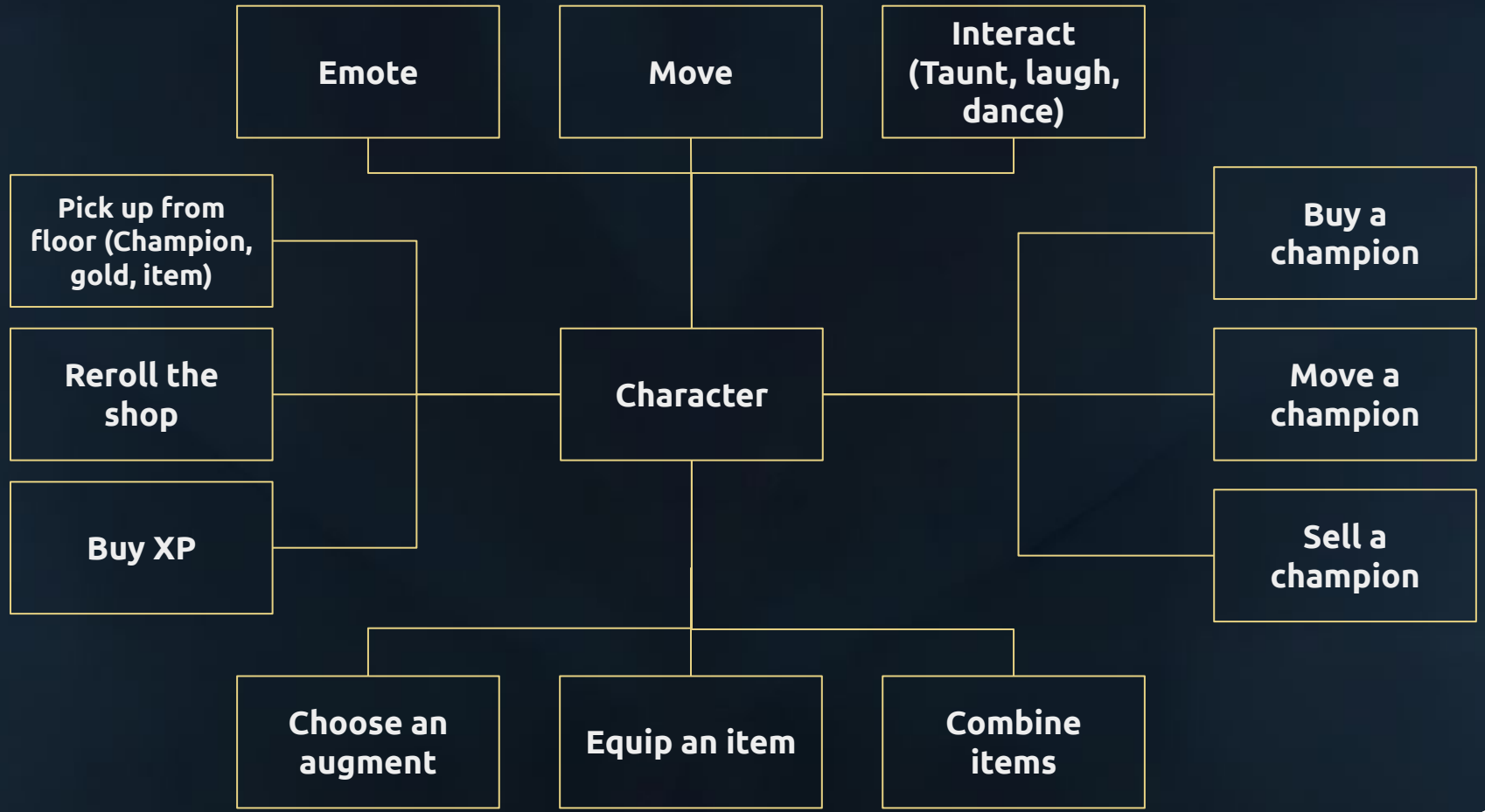
Fixed top-down ¾ camera

**Contextual Camera:**

Zoom to fit on terrain transition

Camera pan on victory

# 3C - Character

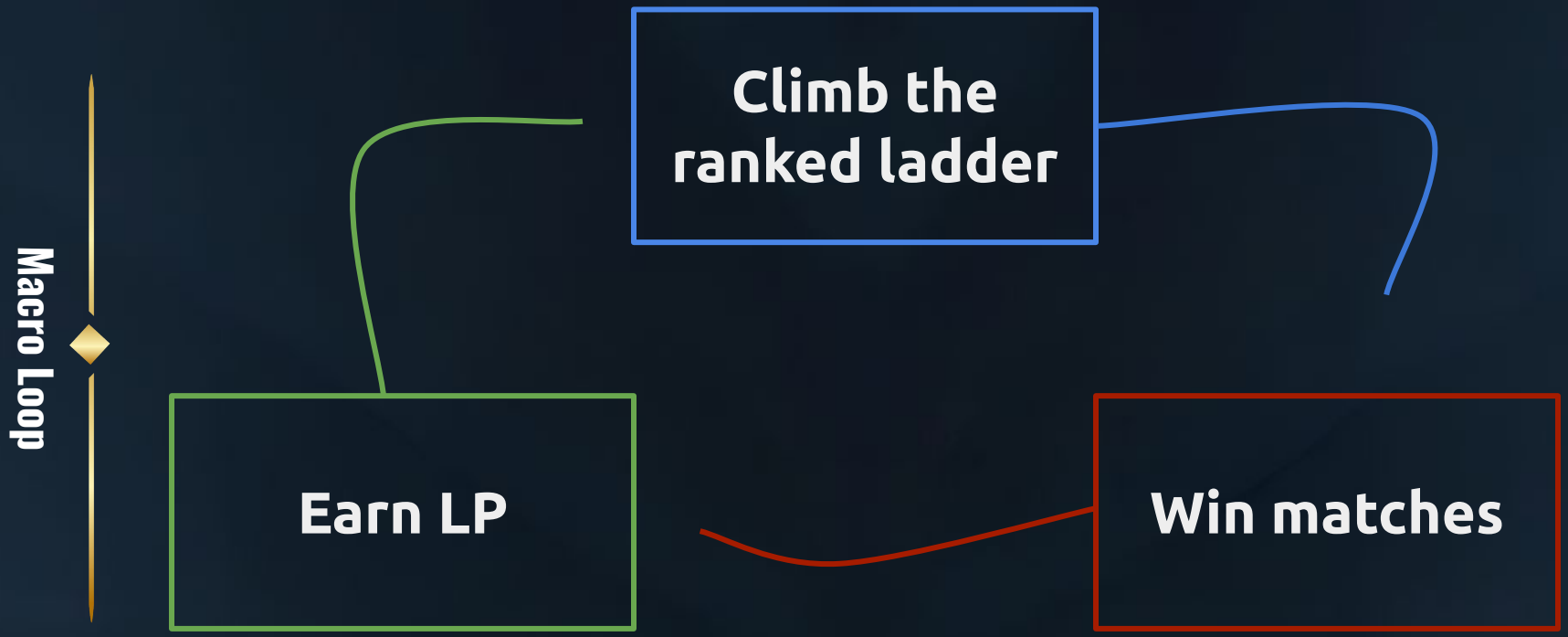


# 3C - Controls

Move
Buy a champion
Interact (emote...)
Choose an augment
Buy a champion
Reroll the shop
Buy XP

Move a champion
Equip an item
Combine items

The TFT Core Loop involves no gameplay change - it is purely cosmetic.


Macro Loop
Climb the ranked ladder
Earn LP
Win matches

Mid Loop

Win a match

. Earn LP
. Earn Battle Pass XP

. Manage your team
. Manage your optimizations
. Manage your positioning
. Manage your builds

Micro Loop

# Place a champion on the board

. Maximize the champion's utility on the board

. Position your champion well
. Think about possible combos based on positioning

Progression

## Competition:

TFT remains a RIOT GAMES title, closely following the studio's standards. The game is FREE TO PLAY with all gameplay content available.
With deep design and a purely competitive focus (aside from temporary PVE modes), TFT fully embraces that.

The ranked ladder is therefore one of the only progression systems in TFT. The game relies entirely on social comparison - both skill-based and through potential conspicuous consumption.

Progression

## Battle Pass:

TFT has only one XP system: the Battle Pass.
The pass resets each season, goes up to level 40 (fixed rewards) but can be extended infinitely (reward loop).

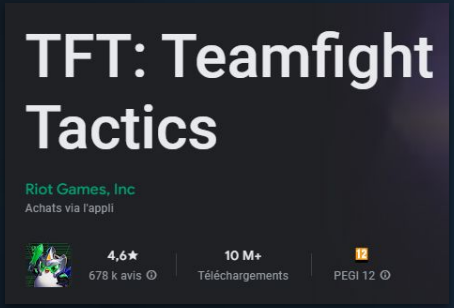
The pass is not directly used as a social comparison tool, but when purchased, it grants exclusive rewards tied to level (skins, effects, currency), playing on conspicuous consumption.
It also introduces the player to Gacha mechanics, which could push them toward spending.

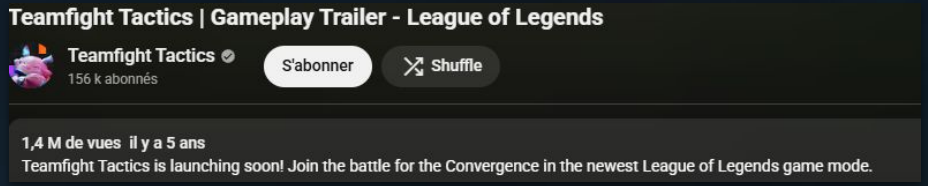
# Acquisition

The acquisition of TFT Mobile rests entirely on the philosophy of its creators, Riot:

TFT follows a formula already proven by competitors and applies its usual standards. The game is 100% free in its gameplay (no pay-to-win mechanics, nothing to unlock via purchase) and only monetizes cosmetic options.

TFT was already a hit on PC with a solid player base, and as a Riot title using the League of Legends license, it naturally leverages this for acquisition to tap into a player base already tied to the studio.



## Retention

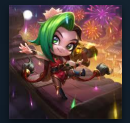
- **Daily quests** for the battle pass
- **Patch system:** Game balance is reviewed every 15 days to refresh the experience and keep things balanced. These patches also refresh the shop. New skins are deployed with each patch, some temporary (to create FOMO).
- **Season system:** A complete gameplay overhaul between seasons. Each season has its own theme and a sort of USP.
- **Temporary game modes:** TFT periodically deploys temporary game modes that change the gameplay.
- **Temporary events:** TFT periodically deploys events (Viego's Black Mist, Arcane Season 1, Arcane Season 2)

# Monetization

The monetization is purely cosmetic. 3 paid axes cover it:

- **Battle Pass:** When purchased, grants access to certain skins with effects. Also allows earning more hard currency.

- **Gacha:** Purchase of hard currency "Treasure Tokens", spendable in the gacha. The gacha includes chances for skins, exclusive skins, hard currency, and effects.



- **Individual skins:** Purchase individual skins at a fixed price in hard currency "Riot Points".

# Formula & Competitors

**Team building**: **Manage** your team, its positioning, and adapt against opponents.

**Combos**: TFT relies heavily on **synergies** between team composition, champion traits, items, positioning, and augments.

**Luck management**: TFT constantly keeps probabilities throughout its gameplay in all directions. The probabilities are **calculable** and are a core part of the **gameplay**.

## DOTA Underlords

**DOTA Underlords** is, like TFT Mobile, a simple **port** of the live game to a mobile platform.
Derived from the **mode** of DOTA that gave birth to the AUTO CHESS genre, DOTA Underlords operates on **nearly the same mechanics** as TFT but in a more simplified form.

## HearthStone Battlegrounds

**Hearthstone Battlegrounds** is further from TFT. It is **not an auto chess**, but was developed as a **fusion** of auto chess mechanics and its base game mechanics (CCG).
Interesting to analyze here: the TFT and HS Battlegrounds communities **frequently interact often** .

Benchmarking

## Pricing :

TFT is caught between several business models. Previously only gacha / individual skin purchases (egg system similar to skin chests), TFT now opens up to a whale market.
The old gacha has become "premium", only accessible for around €150 for a unique skin.

From 2021 to 2024, TFT reportedly generated $523M.

## Team building:

In TFT, team building is a complex and evolving process where the player must constantly adapt to units offered by the shop, to items collected, and to the dynamics of the lobby. Precise grid positioning, management of the economy and champion levels add strategic depth. The game is extremely complete and flexible, although late game relies heavily on scouting opposing players.

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Benchmarking

# DOTA UNDERLORDS

## Pricing:

DOTA Underlords was a quick response to the community game mode of DOTA.
The game was not a clear success: after peaking at 200k players, in 2022 the game lives around 5k monthly players.
Valve discloses no revenue figures for Underlords: One week in Belarus in 2022 generated $30.

The game does not offer large bundles, extremely rare skins, or aggressive purchases. The battle pass is fairly low (€4.99), and other cosmetics are lightweight.

## Team building:

In Dota Underlords, team building revolves around the alliances that the heroes belong to. The shop and items are more predictable, with less variance than in TFT or Battlegrounds, and unit positioning is nearly automatic. This favors a more measured and linear team building approach, with less micro-management but also less flexibility.

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# Hearthstone Battlegrounds

## Pricing:

Hearthstone is a card game where spending money is nearly mandatory.
However in Battlegrounds the entirety of the gameplay is available.
The only in-app purchases are cosmetic.
Prices range from €5 to €25.
This is a game targeting dolphins (mid-spenders).

Revenue figures for Battlegrounds are unavailable, however we have estimates for Hearthstone overall.
In 2022, Hearthstone reportedly generated $61.5M, with the game declining year over year.

## Team building:

In Hearthstone Battlegrounds, team building centers on synergies of unit types, with a simple recruitment system where all units cost the same price. The player must adjust their choices based on options of the shop and their base hero. Placement and unit management are largely automated. Risk-taking, adaptation, and strategy are simplified.

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# Tutorial & FTUE

TFT Mobile technically has no FTUE or tutorial phase. The game only features POPUPs when launching a new account (shown here for the PC version, but equivalent on Mobile).

TFT therefore lets the player figure out the mechanics chaotically? Yes and no.

A new TFT account cannot play ranked matches. It is forced to play 3 normal PVP matches. What the game doesn't tell you: those 3 normal matches are actually PVE against bots that are extremely easy.

The player is therefore eased in over 3 matches, able to test, understand the systems, and experiment without being heavily punished.

## Base:

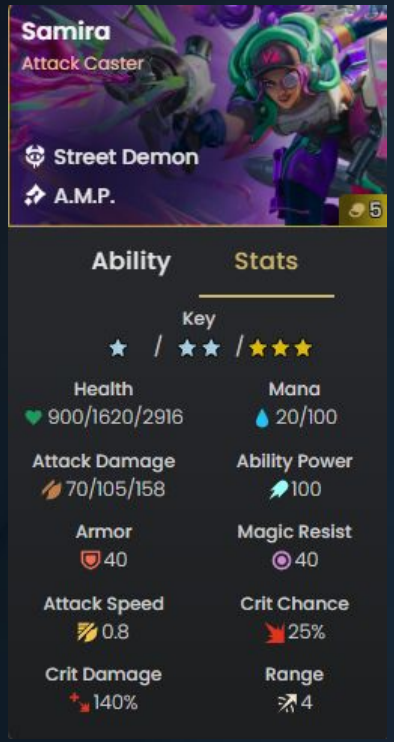
Each TFT unit has a rarity and stats that scale based on star count:

- HP, AD, Armor, AS, Crit%, Crit Dmg, Mana, AP, RM, Range

Units also belong to one or more "family" of champion, each family has a unique passive based on the number of champions of that family active on the board.

Here, this Samira belongs to the Street Demon and A.M.P. She is rarity 5, so the unit costs 5 gold. Her stats are fixed, scaling based on her star level.

To upgrade a unit to more stars, we need 3 units with the same star count. 3 one-star Samiras give 1 two-star Samira. 3 two-star Samiras give 1 three-star Samira.

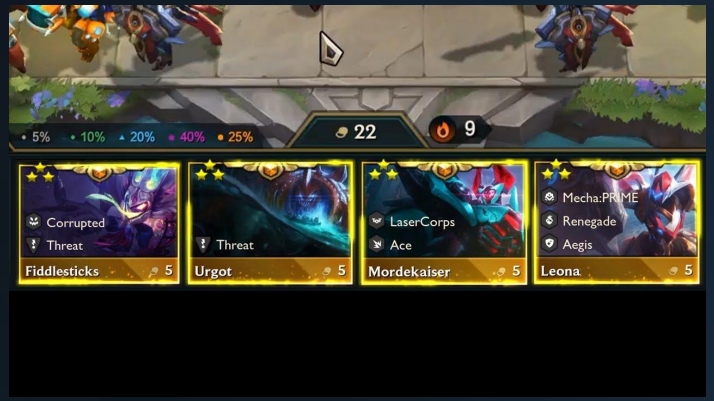


## Shop and placement:

Each TFT unit can be placed on the board. The number of units active on the board equals the level of the player in the match (LVL 1 → 1 champion, LVL 2 → 2 champions...etc). Earning XP is done for free every round, but it can also be purchased.

The shop offers champions for purchase, with rarity matching our level. The higher our level is, the more the shop offers rare units.

The shop refreshes after each round for free, but can also be rerolled for gold.



Metagame

## Items & Carousel:

At the end of each round sequence, the player gets a PVE round. This round lets the player drop units, gold but most importantly items that can be combined. A basic item grants raw stats, a combined one grants an addition of stats plus a passive to the equipped champion.
After this phase, players enter a phase of carousels, random champions with random items are available. Players pick 1 champion (with 1 equipped item) based on their reverse standing, giving last-place players an advantage.

## Augments:

Several times during the match, simultaneously, players get a choice of 3 augments of the same rarity.
These augments grant an exclusive passive. They can be rerolled once.
There are 3 augment rarities:
Silver, Gold, Prismatic

A match includes at most 3 augment selections.

Metagame

## How to become better:

A good TFT player plans, analyzes, and identifies their odds. A good player knows, based on percentages and opponent luck, the probability of getting a given champion or item at a given moment.

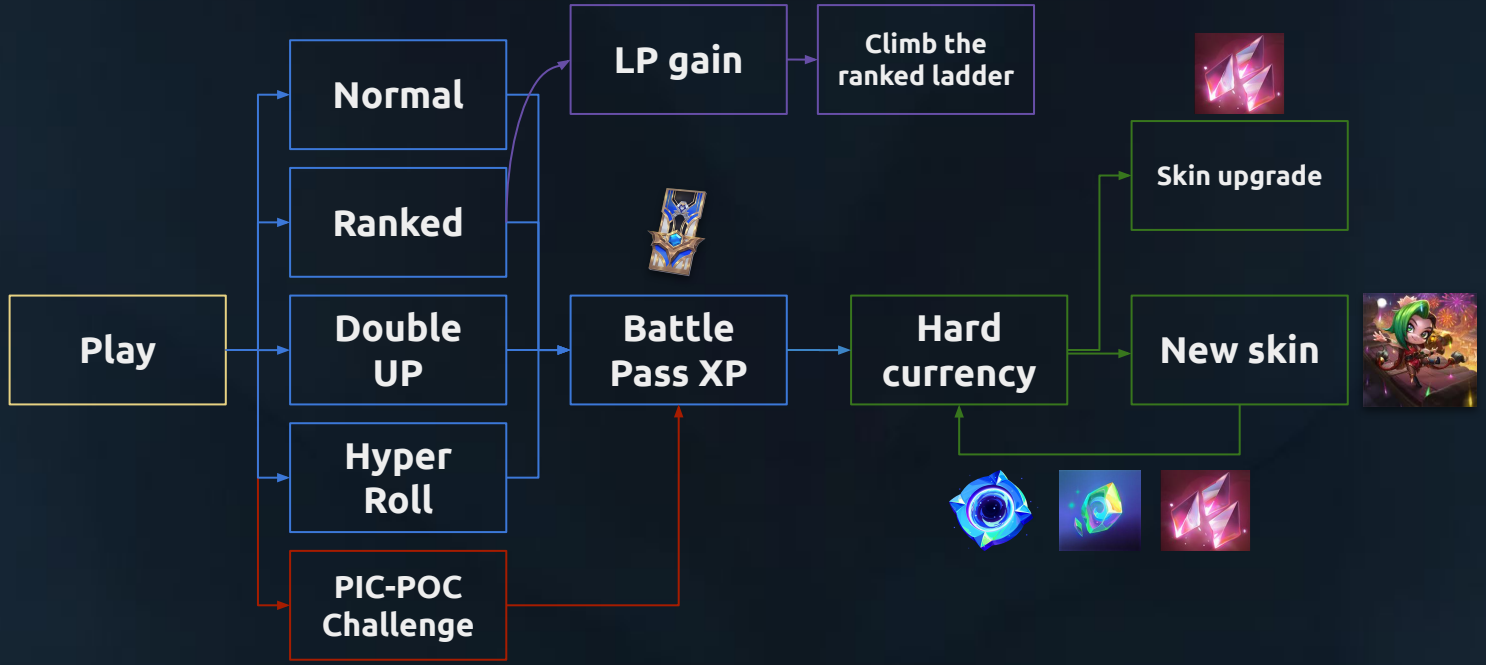
A good player knows the best champion families, the best positioning on the board, and the best items for each champion.

Overall, TFT is a game of mental analysis with very few micro aspects. It is a game that relies largely on macro play.

# Correlation Chart

Completion | Farming | Collection | Social

Layer of Gameplay



Acquisition
A
Upgrade
U
Victory
V
Spending
D
Failure
E
Outcome
O
O
Farm
F
Emotional Trigger
Play
Normal
E
Ranked
E
Double UP
E
Hyper Roll
E
PIC-POC Challenge
E
V
E
U
LP gain
U
Climb the ranked ladder
A
Battle Pass XP
A
Hard currency
U
Skin upgrade
O
A
New skin
O

# THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION!

Special thanks to TFT streamer and pro player "Opesanec" for their help